

# The Power of 3

Electoral compulsions have forced a degree of convergence among once bitter foes who hope to drive a hard bargain after the polls



**| By Ashok K. Damodaran |**

As bedfellows, they are as odd as it gets. Even a few months ago, the very idea of Lalu Prasad Yadav, Mulayam Singh Yadav and Ram Vilas Paswan joining hands to form a "Fourth Front" would have been quite unthinkable. Part of the original batch of Mandalites, each grew in size and stature and believed he was bigger than the other two put together. Their parting of ways after the fall of V.P. Singh's National Front government in 1990 was, therefore, inevitable. Much water has flown down the Gomti and the Kosi since then and the trio, who would not even acknowledge each other at social gatherings, have been forced by circumstances to bearhug one another in front of TV cameras.

Electoral compulsions have sud-

denly forced a degree of convergence. In Bihar, Lalu's famed Muslim-Yadav combination is coming apart and the panic is evident in the railway minister's sudden offensive against the Congress which included the charge that the grand old party was as responsible as the BJP for the Babri Masjid demolition. It is not surprising that Lalu is making the right noises to court Muslim voters who account for over 16 per cent of the electorate in Bihar. Over the years, Lalu has not tired of targeting Lal Krishna Advani and taking credit for the arrest of the BJP's prime ministerial candidate in October 1990. Cut to 2009. Perhaps few eyebrows were raised when Lalu claimed he would have "flattened Varun Gandhi with a roller if he were the country's home minister".

Lalu's swipe at the Congress is a huge paradigm shift because he is now

clearly drifting apart from his onetime rock solid ally. This is, however, not without reasons. Lalu's no-holds-barred attack on the Congress perhaps underlines his desperation because the Muslims in his state, unlike earlier times, have discovered multiple options other than his Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) to vote for.

The timing is of equal importance. Lalu has bared his fangs against the Congress after the first phase of polling, which suggests that perhaps the feedback has not been very good to him. He could now be trying harder to compensate because 27 seats are still to witness the battle of ballots in Bihar. Clearly, Lalu Prasad, who always considered the Muslim vote as among the lynchpins in his political plans, is unnerved. By launching a negative tirade against everyone, he is trying hard to polarise Muslims in his favour.